

but believe France should remain in Algeria. He points out that his methods are the only way to achieve that. He understands the pyramid cell structure of the FLN, and that torturing suspects is the only way to move up that pyramid to the leadership—as he puts it, to “cut off the head of the tapeworm.”

The 20th century saw the world become a global community, in which advances in communication technology meant that no war could pass out of sight, no violent act be hidden. *The Battle of Algiers* proposes that winning a modern conflict is not necessarily about might. Mathieu is a stronger tactician than the FLN and gradually defeats the group on the ground, and yet, ultimately, Algeria still gains independence, because the FLN's action ignited public opinion about the country's right to self-determination. Mathieu won the battle in Algiers, but ultimately the French lost the war.

The nature of war

The Battle of Algiers is a movie about the Algerian struggle for independence, yet it is also a movie about the nature of conflict. Its themes are universal, and the

Key incidents in the Battle of Algiers



questions it poses about the lines people cross for what they believe are still extremely pertinent and difficult to answer. It is also perhaps the most clear-headed movie about war ever made, not swayed by the emotions that might cloud the issue, interested in the cold tactics of both sides without overtly demonizing either side. The movie clearly believes in Algeria's

right to independence, but at the same time has respect for Mathieu's honesty, dignity, and competence. In the end, it even allows him a moment of decency as he pleads with Ali to allow the teenage boy in his company to leave the field of battle. This moment defines the whole movie. War is not simply about having a just cause. It is also about what we do in its name. ■

Gillo Pontecorvo Director



Gillo Pontecorvo was born in Pisa, Italy in 1919. His first job in the movie industry was in Paris working as an assistant to Joris Ivens, a Dutch documentary filmmaker with Marxist views. Pontecorvo shared Ivens' politics, becoming a member of the Italian Communist Party in 1941. He was primarily a documentary filmmaker, and *The Battle of Algiers* was one of the few times Pontecorvo ventured into more overtly dramatic work. He

remained true to his documentarian principles, however, hiring mostly nonprofessional actors, including the ex-FLN leader Yacef Saadi. Pontecorvo died from heart failure in Rome in 2006.

Key movies

1960 *Kapò*
1966 *The Battle of Algiers*
1969 *Burn!*
1979 *Ogro*